Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

1.1 Metadata

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 27-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.2 Definitions

- **file** - data on storage device, e.g., hard disk or ssd
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.3 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣`, `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.4 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2> ... <filen>
helix <directory>
helix --help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Editing Paradigm

Selection first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
        v3wd – enter select mode, select 3 words, delete
```

2.2 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

```
         . – any character
         * – zero or more
         + – one or more
         ? – zero or one / lazy match
         ^ – start of line / negation in class
         $ – end of line
       ( ) – capture group
       [ ] – character class
       { } – repetition count
         | – alternation
         \ – escape character itself
```

2.3 Essentials

2.3.1 Undo / Repeat / Normal Mode

```
         u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history
  :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by step
                count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
    <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
           Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.3.2 Quit

Add ! suffix to force operation.

```
        :wq – write current buffer and quit
  :wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
        :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
         :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.3.3 Files

```
  :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
  :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>
 :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
 :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
        ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal
              split
        ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical
              split
         gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url
              under selection.
         ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
         ␣F – open file picker at current working directory
         ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.3.3.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
   <enter> – open selected in current view
    Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
    Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.3.4 Buffers

Add ! suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
        :n – create new scratch buffer
       :bc – close current buffer
      :bca – close all buffers
      :bco – close all but current buffer
       :bn – next buffer
        ␣b – open buffer picker
        ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
        gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
        gn – go to next buffer
        gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.3.5 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
 ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
        ␣wq – close current split
        ␣wo – close all but current split
        ␣ww – next split
  ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
  ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
        ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.3.5.1 View Movement

Commands shown with `z` prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
         Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
     zz, zc – align to center
         zt – align to top
         zb – align to bottom
         zm – align to middle horizontally
         zj – scroll down
         zk – scroll up
```

2.3.6 Help

```
     :tutor – open tutorial
         ␣? – open command palette
```

2.4 Movement

2.4.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
     h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
     gh, g| – beginning of line
     <nn>g| – column <nn>
         gl – end of line
         gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
         ge – bottom of file
         gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word
         g.– to last modification in current file
         gj – down textual line
         gk – up textual line
         gs – first non-white-space char
         gt – top of screen
         gc – middle of screen
         gb – bottom of screen
```

2.4.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
         gd – go to definition
         gy – go to type definition
         gr – go to references
         gi – go to implementation
         ]d – next diagnostic
         [d – prior diagnostic
         ]D – last diagnostic
         [D – first diagnostic
```

2.4.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
     ]f, [f – to next, prior function
     ]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
     ]T, [T – to next, prior test
     ]a, [a – to next, prior arg
     ]c, [c – to next, prior comment
     ]g, [g – to next, prior change
     ]G, [G – to last, first change
     Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
     Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.4.4 By Page

```
    Ctrl-b – page up
    Ctrl-f – page down
    Ctrl-u – half page up
    Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.5 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.5.1 Operations

```
         % – select whole file
     Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
     Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
     Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
     Alt-i – shrink selection
         ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.5.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object indicated
                  by <ch> below:
           w / W – word / WORD
               p – paragraph
  (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
               m – closest surround pair
               f – function
               t – type or class
               a – argument/parameter
               c – comment
               T – test
               g – change git hunk
```

2.5.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
           w / W – to start of next word / WORD
           e / E – to end of current word / WORD
           b / B – to start of current word / WORD
               x – current line, extend by line
               X – extend to line
        Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
           ]p – to next paragraph
           [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.5.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
     Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
     Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
     Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
     Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
     Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
     Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.5.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
  f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
  t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
       Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.6 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
         v – toggle select mode
       Esc – return to normal
         ) – cycle primary selection forward
         ( – cycle primary selection backward
     Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.7 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.7.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
  s<regex> – matches become selections
         S – split on match
     Alt-s – split on newlines
 C / Alt-C – add selection below / above
```

2.7.2 Operations

```
         & – align on primary cursor
 Alt-<minus> – merge selections
 Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
           , – remove all except primary selection
      Alt-,  – remove primary selection
       ( / ) – rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward / forward
         K – keep selections matching the regex
     Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.8 Alter Buffer Content

2.8.1 Insert

```
         i – before selection
         a – after selection
         I – at start of line
         A – at end of line
         o – add line and insert below cursor
         O – add line and insert above cursor
       Esc – end insert (return to normal)
         . – repeat last insert
```

2.8.2 Add

```
        ]␣ – newline below
        [␣ – newline above
    ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.8.3 Delete

```
         d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
     Alt-d – delete, no save
    md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.8.4 Change

```
         c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
     Alt-c – change, no save
         = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.8.5 Indent Lines

```
         > – Indent line(s) containing selection
         < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.8.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
         ~ – change case
           – set lowercase
     Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.8.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
         ␣C – Toggle block comment
     ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.8.8 Increment / Decrement

```
    Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
    Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.8.9 Miscellaneous

```
         J – join lines in a selection
     Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the
             inserted space
    <under> – trim whitespace from selection
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>, default 80
     :sort – sort ranges in selection
   :format – format file using external formatter /
             language server
```

2.9 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
         y – selection -> yank buf
         p – paste yank buf after the cursor
         P – paste yank buf before the cursor
        ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
        ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
        ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
     r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
         R – replace selection with yank buf
         " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.10 Search

```
   /<regex> – search forward for regex
   ?<regex> – search backward for regex
       n, N – next, previous match
          * – search for current selection, respect word
              boundaries
      Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.11 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
     "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
    "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
    "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
    "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.12 Macros

```
    "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
    "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.13 Jumplists

```
    Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
    Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
    Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
        ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.14 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
        mm – go to matching delim
    mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
    ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
    ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
    md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.15 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
         | – replace selection(s) with output
     Alt-| – ignore output
         ! – insert output before each selection(s)
     Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
         $ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.16 Approaching an IDE

```
        ␣G – debug - experimental
        ␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
        ␣s – open document symbol picker
        ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
        ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
        ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
        ␣r – rename symbol
        ␣a – apply code action
        ␣h – select symbol references for symbol under
             cursor
```

2.17 Editor Configuration

```
     :config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
   :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.18 Miscellaneous

```
        ␣' – open last picker
        ␣/ – open global search in workspace folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                    Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                    Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                    Ctrl-r – insert a register content
         Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
          Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                    Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                    Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
   Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-– delete previous char
                     <bksp>
             Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
           Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line
   <Up>, <Down>, <Left>,– usual meaning but
      <Right>, <PageUp>,   discouraged
<PageDown>, <Home>, <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
           Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
             <enter> – open selected
               <tab> – select next completion item
           <backtab> – select previous completion item
              Alt-b – backward a word
             Ctrl-b – backward a char
              Alt-f – forward a word
             Ctrl-f – forward a char
             Ctrl-e – to prompt end
             Ctrl-a – to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
 Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
             Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
             Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
       <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
          <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
             Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may
                      be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
             Ctrl-p – select previous history
             Ctrl-n – select next history
             Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register
                      selected by following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
    <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                   <Home> – to first entry
                    <End> – to last entry
         Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
       Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
                  <enter> – open selected
            Alt-<enter> – open selected in the
                          background without closing
                          the picker
                  Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                  Ctrl-v – open vertically
                  Ctrl-t – toggle preview
             Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
    Ctrl-u – scroll up
    Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
      Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
          <enter> – close menu and accept completion
           Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
    Alt-p – previous signature
    Alt-n – next signature
```